Course guide:

EKHM87 - Advanced Analysis of Economic Change

Spring semester 2026

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Changes may still occur.

A. **Course description**

This course analyses the major debates in development economics from a long-term perspective. Economists and economic historians are increasingly aware that the process of economic growth is complex and often characterized by path dependency. There is also increasing attention for variation in institutional settings and their consequences, like differences in economic behaviour and economic outcomes. This course reflects these developments by focusing on economic evolution in the long run and on variations between societies.

Questions central to the course are*: 'can we determine historical roots of why some countries are rich and others poor, and if so, how do we approach this?'; 'what is the role of the different factors of production in long run economic development?'; 'what role do critical historical junctures play in long run development?', and why is income so much more unequally divided in some countries than in others?'*.

During the course, students will learn about the different methods used in modern research through an in-depth study of the literature and hands-on econometric exercises. Explorative methodologies versus hypothesis testing are discussed. Exercises are performed with the help of econometric software whereby students are trained in the use of statistical tools but also in understanding and interpreting quantitative results in an historical context.

This course is organised around 4 lectures that provide analytical frameworks and 5 seminars where you actively work with academic research as analysts and evaluators. The aim is not to memorise a large number of topics, but to learn how economists and economic historians explain long-run economic change using theory, data, and historical evidence.
You will repeatedly work with academic papers, not to summarise them, but to critically assess their arguments and think about how the analysis could be improved. This way of working prepares you both for the exam and for more advanced academic work.
The course is divided into two thematic blocks, each introduced by a lecture and explored through seminars.

B. Practical work

The practical component of the course consists of seminar participation, two replication exercises, and an in-class analytical exercise, all designed to train students in evaluating empirical research, understanding identification strategies, and interpreting quantitative results in their historical context.

Seminars are organised as applied research workshops in which students work directly with academic papers, participating once as **Authors** (defending research design choices and proposing improvements) and once as **Referees** (critically assessing identification, measurement, and causal interpretation).
The course further includes **two replication exercises** using econometric software. The first is a common, pre-defined replication of a seminal paper in long-run development. The second builds on the paper selected by the student in their Author role and focuses on extending or modifying an existing empirical analysis.

Finally, students complete an **in-class handwritten analytical exercise**, which assesses their ability to structure and communicate analytical reasoning under time constraints. Together, these activities emphasise methodological reasoning, causal inference, and the interpretation of empirical evidence rather than memorisation.

Seminars:
Students are required to actively participate in at least two seminars during the course. Seminars are organised as applied research workshops, in which students work directly with academic papers.
Each student participates in two seminars on different dates:

1. once as an Author (defending the authors' choices), and
2. once as a Referee.

When participating as an Author, students choose a paper that corresponds to the seminar theme and prepare it in depth. Authors are expected to understand and defend the paper's research design, identify its main contribution, and propose realistic improvements or extensions.
When participating as a Referee, students are assigned a paper (which they did not choose themselves) after seminar sign-up closes. Referees prepare a structured critique focusing on identification, measurement, assumptions, causal interpretation, and on how the analysis could be improved.

Seminars are discussion-based. Although work is organised around shared papers, assessment is individual and focuses on analytical reasoning, methodological understanding, and active engagement.

Paper selection
Papers must be chosen as early as possible. Please note that the paper you

choose for your Author role will also determine the topic of your second replication exercise (Replication II). Early paper selection is therefore important for planning both your seminar preparation and your replication work. Replicable papers can be found here: https://ejd.econ.mathematik.uni-ulm.de/

Replication exercises:

During the course, students are required to do two replication exercises. Exercises are performed using Stata whereby students are required to utilize statistical tools but also show an understanding of the quantitative results in its (historical) context. The basis for these exercises should be a seminal paper that contains a quantitative analysis focusing on long run development. The aim of the activity is to understand how quantitative analyses are performed, how data is collected and processed, and to understand the importance of historical context to meaningfully interpret results.

The exercises involve three parts.

- The first part is a replication of the main results of the original paper.
- The second part involves a critical analysis of the original results based on additional (historical) readings, on additional sensitivity analyses (student's design), a discussion of the (historical) data quality, robustness of the results, etc.
- The third step involves a written report with a reflection of the quality of the original results in the context of the additional material collected and analyzed.

The report should be no longer than 1750 words maximum (excluding an appendix and replication results).

The first replication assignment is based on the following paper: Nunn, N. (2008). The Long-term Effects of Africa's Slave Trades, The Quarterly Journal of Economics, Volume 123, Issue 1, Pp. 139–176, https://doi.org/10.1162/qjec.2008.123.1.139.
Assignments need to be handed in via Canvas on Tuesday February 24th, 2026 at midnight.

For the second replication assignment students can choose an article of interest. Articles with available replication data can be found here: https://ejd.econ.mathematik.uni-ulm.de/

The second assignment needs to be handed in on March 20th, 2026 at midnight

C. Course schedule

Week	Day	Date	Time	Activity	Room / Platform	Instructor
BLOCK 0 – Course introduction						
v6	Thursday	2026-02-05	12:00–14:00	**Lecture 1**	EC2:101	AC
BLOCK 1 – Institutions						
v7	Tuesday	2026-02-10	13:00–15:00	**Lecture 2**	EC2:101	AC
v7	Thursday	2026-02-12	09:00–15:00	Seminar 1: Institutions	Alfa1:1104	AC
v8	Monday	2026-02-16	09:00–15:00	Seminar 2: Extractive Institutions	Alfa1:1104	AC
v8	Tuesday	2026-02-17	09:00–15:00	Seminar 3: Institutions conducive to economic growth	Alfa1:1104	AC
v9	Monday	2026-02-23	12:00–14:00	**Lab**	Alfa1:2067	AC
v9	Tuesday	2026-02-24	00:00	**Replication Exercise I**	CANVAS	
BLOCK 2 – Demographic change						
v9	Wednesday	2026-02-25	10:00–12:00	**Lecture 3**	EC3:207	MC
v10	Monday	2026-03-02	09:00–15:00	Seminar 4: Demographic change and behaviour	Alfa1:1104	MC
v10	Tuesday	2026-03-03	09:00–15:00	Seminar 5: Demographic change and inequality	Alfa1:1104	MC
BLOCK 3 – Synthesis and assessment						
v11	Tuesday	2026-03-10	10:00–12:00	**Lecture 4**	EC2:101	AC
v12	Monday	2026-03-16	10:00–12:00	Q&A	Alfa1:2067	ACA
v12	Wednesday	2026-03-18	13:00–14:00	**In-class handwritten analytical exercise**	EC1:136	AC
v12	Friday	2026-03-20	—	**Replication II – submission**	Canvas —	AC

D. Examination and grading

Grading is based on individual performance, via a written exam, assignments, reports, presentations and other mandatory activities. The course includes two replication exercises that the students need to submit on **24th of February**, and **20th of March at midnight at the latest.**

The final grade is determined by the following five components, each contributing **20%** to the total course grade:

1. **Seminar participation – Author role (20%)**
   Students participate once as Authors, working in pairs, in a peer-review seminar. Assessment is individual and based on analytical reasoning, methodological understanding, and engagement. Individual performance is graded as *Pass / Good / Excellent (50%/75%/100%)*. Participation is compulsory.
2. **Seminar participation – Referee role (20%)**
   Students participate once as Referees, working in pairs, in a different peer-review seminar. Assessment is individual and based on critical evaluation, identification of weaknesses, and constructive analytical feedback. Performance is graded as *Pass / Good / Excellent (50%/75%/100%)*. Participation is compulsory.
3. **Replication exercise I – Common replication (20%)**
   A pre-defined replication exercise based on a seminal paper in long-run economic development.
   Submission deadline: 20 February (23:59).
4. **Replication exercise II – Paper-based replication (20%)**
   A replication or extension exercise based on the paper worked on as an Author during the seminars.
   Submission deadline: 20 March (23:59).
5. **In-class handwritten analytical exercise (20%)**
   A time-bounded in-class analytical exercise completed individually and without access to books or notes. The exercise assesses analytical reasoning, understanding of mechanisms, and identification rather than writing style.

Grades for the replication analyses and the handwritten exercise will follow the **A- F** criterion-based scale used by the School of Economics and Management at Lund University.

Grade	Points	Characteristics
A (Excellent)	100-85	A distinguished result that is excellent with regard to the following aspects – theoretical depth, practical relevance, analytical ability and independent thought.
B (Very good)	84-75	A very good result with regard to the above-mentioned aspects.

C (Good)	74-65	The result is of a good standard with regard to the above-mentioned aspects and lives up to expectations.
D (Satisfactory)	64-55	The result is of a satisfactory standard with regard to the above-mentioned aspects and lives up to expectations.
E (Sufficient)	54-50	The result satisfies the minimum requirements with regard to the above-mentioned aspects, but not more.
U/F (fail)	49-0	The result does not meet the minimum requirements with regard to the above-mentioned aspects.

The **final course grade** is calculated as the weighted average of these five components. Failing to come to one of these activities without a valid justification will result in a qualification of 0 for this assignment.

Individual Final grade = 0.2 × Author seminar + 0.2 × Referee seminar + 0.2 × Replication I + 0.2 × Replication II + 0.2 × In-class analytical exercise[1]

Academic Integrity and AI Use

This course follows strict policies on plagiarism and the responsible use of AI-based tools to maintain the highest standards of academic integrity. It is crucial that all students understand and adhere to these guidelines to ensure fair and honest assessment.

The examiner, in consultation with Disability Support Services, may deviate from the regular form of examination in order to provide a permanently disabled student with a form of examination equivalent to that of a student without a disability.

Plagiarism Policy:

The University views plagiarism very seriously, and will take disciplinary actions against students for any kind of attempted malpractice in examinations and assessments. All written assignments and submissions will be checked for plagiarism using **Ouriginal**. Plagiarism is defined as using someone else's work without proper citation or reusing your own previous work without permission. **Every assignment must be an original contribution, and any suspected plagiarism will be reported to the Disciplinary Board at Lund University**. For more details on what constitutes plagiarism and the consequences, please refer to the full policy.

AI Use Policy:

The Department encourages the responsible and ethical use of AI-based tools (e.g., ChatGPT, Bing AI, Whisper) to support learning, but students must take full personal ownership of their work. If you use AI tools in your assignments, you must clearly state how they were used and how the work was divided

[1] These assignments are compulsory. Failure to come to assignments 1,2 or 5 without a valid justification will reward the grade of 0. Students may still pass the course if the rest of the assignment' grades allow. Non presential assignments will allow a retake.

between you and the tool. In some cases, complementary examination methods (e.g., oral exams) may be required to verify the originality of your work. Unauthorized use of AI tools or uploading course materials to AI systems is prohibited. For more detailed guidelines, please review the full AI Policy.
A template is available in the General Documentation of the course.

Full lecture plan – Advanced Analysis of Economic Change

Lecture 1 – Introduction: long-run economic change and how we study it
(Week 6, 2 hours) Alexandra L. Cermeño

Purpose
To frame the course intellectually and methodologically, and to explain *how* and *why* students will be working with academic papers as analysts and evaluators rather than as passive readers.
Core questions

- Why do we study economic change in the long run?
- What makes historical explanations different from short-run economic analysis?
- How do institutions, human capital, and demography enter explanations of growth and inequality?

BLOCK 1:

How do different institutional arrangements shape incentives, behaviour, and long-run economic outcomes — and how can we credibly identify these effects in historical data?

Lecture 2 – Institutions: growth-conducive and growth-hindering rules of the game
(Week 7, 2 hours – opening of Block I) Alexandra L. Cermeño
Purpose: To provide the **single theoretical framework** that underpins all three seminars in the institutions block.
Core question: Why do some institutional arrangements promote long-run growth and broad-based prosperity, while others generate stagnation, extraction, and inequality?

Seminar 1: Institutions and long run development
How do institutions shape incentives and long-run economic outcomes?
Seminar 2: Extractive institutions and historical persistence
When and how do "bad" institutions like slavery hinder development?
Seminar 3: Human capital accumulation as an institutional system of rewards
How do institutions promote growth through investment in people (human capital)?

BLOCK 2:

Lecture 3 – Long-run demographic change and economic transformation
(Week 9, 2 hours – opening of Block II) Marcos Castillo
Purpose: To introduce demographic change as a slow-moving structural force that interacts with institutions and human capital in shaping living standards and inequality.
Core question: How did long-run changes in mortality, fertility, and migration reshape how people lived, worked, and invested in the future?

Seminar 4: Demographic change and economic behaviour

How do changes in mortality, fertility, and migration alter individual and collective behaviour?

Seminar 5: Demography, inequality, and measurement

Who benefits from demographic change, and how can we measure it?

Lecture 4 –persistence, path dependence, and economic change

(Week 11, 2 hours – closing lecture) Alexandra L. Cermeno

Purpose: To integrate the institutions and demography blocks through the concept of **persistence**, and to prepare students for individual assessment by revisiting how mechanisms, identification, and historical data interact to produce long-run outcomes.

Course core literature:

This course is highly student-driven. As a result, the specific literature discussed in seminars and in class will partly depend on students' choices of papers, particularly for seminar participation and replication exercises

- **Abramitzky, R., Boustan, L. P., & Eriksson, K. (2012).** Europe's tired, poor, huddled masses: Self-selection and economic outcomes in the age of mass migration. *American Economic Review*, *102*(5), 1832-1856.
- **Acemoglu, D., Johnson, S., & Robinson, J. A. (2001).** The Colonial Origins of Comparative Development: An Empirical Investigation. *American Economic Review*, 91(5), 1369–1401.
- **Acemoglu, D., Johnson, S., & Robinson, J. A. (2002).** Reversal of Fortune: Geography and Institutions in the Making of the Modern World Income Distribution. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 117(4), 1231–1294.
- **Aizer, A., Eli, S., Ferrie, J., & Lleras-Muney, A. (2016).** The long-run impact of cash transfers to poor families. *American Economic Review*, *106*(4), 935-971.
- **Albouy, D. (2012).** The Colonial Origins of Comparative Development: An Empirical Investigation: Comment. *American Economic Review*, 102(6), 3059–3076.
- **Alfani, G., & Murphy, T. E. (2017).** Plague and Lethal Epidemics in the Pre-Industrial World. *Journal of Economic History*, 77(1), 314–343.
- **Almond, D. (2006).** Is the 1918 influenza pandemic over? Long-term effects of in utero influenza exposure in the post-1940 US population. *Journal of Political Economy*, *114*(4), 672-712.
- **Alvaredo, F., Atkinson, A. B., Piketty, T., & Saez, E. (2013).** The Top 1 Percent in International and Historical Perspective. *Journal of Economic Perspectives*, 27(3), 3–20.
- **Austin, G. (2008).** The "Reversal of Fortune" Thesis and the Compression of History: Perspectives from African and Comparative Economic History. *Journal of International Development*, 20(8), 996–1027.
- **Becker, S. O., & Woessmann, L. (2009).** Was Weber Wrong? A Human Capital Theory of Protestant Economic History. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 124(2), 531–559.
- **Bentzen, J. S. (2019).** Acts of God? Religiosity and Natural Disasters across Subnational World Districts. *Economic Journal*, 129(622), 2295–2321.

- **Bezemer, D., Bolt, J., & Lensink, R. (2014).** Slavery, Statehood, and Economic Development in Sub-Saharan Africa. *World Development*, 57, 149–163.
- **Bleakley, H., & Ferrie, J. (2016).** Shocking behavior: Random wealth in antebellum Georgia and human capital across generations. *The quarterly journal of economics*, *131*(3), 1455-1495.
- **Cleland, J., & Wilson, C. (1987).** Demand Theories of the Fertility Transition: An Iconoclastic View. *Population Studies*, 41(1), 5–30.
- **Cogneau, D., & Moradi, A. (2014).** Borders That Divide: Education and Religion in Ghana and Togo since Colonial Times. *Journal of Economic History*, 74(3), 694–729.
- **Dell, M., Jones, B. F., & Olken, B. A. (2012).** Temperature Shocks and Economic Growth: Evidence from the Last Half Century. *American Economic Journal: Macroeconomics*, 4(3), 66–95.
- **Easterly, W., & Levine, R. (2016).** The European Origins of Economic Development. *Journal of Economic Growth*, 21(3), 225–257.
- **Frankema, E., Green, E., & Hillbom, E. (2016).** Endogenous Processes of Colonial Settlement: The Success and Failure of European Settler Farming in Sub-Saharan Africa. *Revista de Historia Económica / Journal of Iberian and Latin American Economic History*, 34(2), 237–265.
- **Jones, C. I. (2016).** The Facts of Economic Growth. In *Handbook of Macroeconomics*, Vol. 2A. Elsevier.
- **Kersting, F., Wohnsiedler, I., & Wolf, N. (2020).** Weber Revisited: The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Nationalism. *Journal of Economic History*, 80(3), 710–745.
- **Nunn, N. (2008).** The Long-Term Effects of Africa's Slave Trades. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 123(1), 139–176.
- **Sánchez-Alonso, B. (2019).** The Age of Mass Migration in Latin America. *Economic History Review*, 72(1), 3–31.
- **Sequeira, S., Nunn, N., & Qian, N. (2020).** Immigrants and the Making of America. *Review of Economic Studies*, 87(1), 382–419.
- **Spolaore, E., & Wacziarg, R. (2022).** Fertility and Modernity. *Economic Journal*, 132(642), 796–833.
- **Tabellini, M. (2020).** Gifts of the Immigrants, Woes of the Natives: Lessons from the Age of Mass Migration. *Review of Economic Studies*, 87(1), 454–486.
- **Voigtländer, N., & Squicciarini, M. P. (2015).** Human Capital and Industrialization: Evidence from the Age of Enlightenment. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 130(4), 1825–1883.